

MANISH BHANDARI



LALBABU PRASAD, 16 In May 2009, armed men accosted Prasad (above) when he was coming out of a coaching centre on a sultry afternoon. They took him to a temple in the adjoining Jehanabad district where he was forced to marry 13-year-old Babita (left) at gunpoint. The two families are yet to reach an amicable agreement.

VIKASH KUMAR, 17 Son of a former village chief, he was abducted and forced to marry Juli, a Class IX student in 2009. Kumar, in high school now, has agreed to accept Juli as his wife as his father has reached an agreement with his in-laws.



ASHOK PRIYADARSHI

now agreed to accept the bride Vinita with whom the boy was forced to tie the knot. On February 11, Rai was kidnapped when he went out to sell milk. The boy was taken to the girl's home, in a nearby village of Patna district, and after a day of captivity was made to marry 10-year-old Vinita. Under pressure, he allowed himself to be married to a girl he had never seen before and who also was not of legally marriageable age. Rai's father Ram Pravesh Rai, who had filed a missing person complaint, has now agreed to accept the alliance. "My daughter-in-law is with her parents now but she will join us soon. What can I do if the marriage has already been solemnised? An agreement has been reached," says the father.

Independent surveys by INDIA TODAY suggest that of late the rate of opposition to these abductions for

marriages has steadily grown in the last few years, although a majority of the involved families, like that of Rai, prefer rapprochement to police cases. The abduction of boys for marriage has taken shape with the passage of time because of a slew of social evils like dowry. It is invariably the bride's family that carries the material load of arranging marriages. It becomes such a burden that it often leads to "de-valuation" of girls in traditional societies like one that Bihar has. Since marriages have become a money-minting enterprise for parents of boys, many families have adopted desperate measures like abducting a bridegroom because they cannot arrange a decent dowry for their daughter's marriage.

Such families in Bihar have continued to snatch men—often young boys—because it is easier than

approaching the boys' families and cheaper than paying the standard dowry. Kamta Singh, chairman of a primary agriculture credit society in Rampur, Nawada, claims that almost 90 per cent marriages in the villages have been solemnised by kidnapping a bridegroom. According to villagers, a good number of boys are kidnapped and married off during matriculation examination when they come to appear at the Narhat examination centre from adjoining villages. In almost all such cases, the villagers extend support to the girl's family. The ceremony is videographed so that the tapes can be used as evidence later. In fact, priests of village temples fully cooperate with the girl's family and issue a certificate of marriage. Clearly, the approval from society for such marriages has emboldened the public to take the law into their hands. The practice has technically been illegal for years, but the law rarely has been enforced. Brutal as the custom is, it is widely perceived as practical. "Most people don't care it's illegal because there is a very high possibility of reconciliation. The boy's family frets and fumes after the marriage but only to raise a dowry demand. Assured that the boy is now theirs, the girl's parents are also willing to settle things by offering one-fourth of the usual dowry that they would have had to offer if the boy was not already married," said Hetukar Jha, a retired sociology professor at Patna University.

Most forced marriages have survived, as the disputes arising out of them are settled in the village itself, with the elders bringing about rapprochement between the two families on grounds of the girl's future. Though forced marriages have traditionally been prevalent among the so-called upper castes in Bihar, the practice is picking up even among the middle castes where the demand for dowry has skyrocketed over the years. Besides, parents have also become more ambitious. They want to marry their daughters